Values vs. Goals

Based on Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), developed by Steven C. Hayes, Kirk Strosahl, and Kelly Wilson

1 WHAT IS IT?

In Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), values are the qualities you want to bring to your life, like being caring, curious, or honest. Goals are specific outcomes you can achieve and check off. Values are a direction; goals are places you reach along the way.

2 HOW DOES IT WORK?

Values

- Qualities of how you act
- Available right now
- Never finished

"How do I want to show up?"

Goals

- Specific outcomes
- Can be achieved, checked off
- Focused on the future

"What do I want to get?"

The compass image is a common ACT metaphor; this illustration is original.

3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

Goals are useful, but living only for outcomes can leave us empty once they're reached, or stuck in "I'll be okay when…" Values are available right now, in small actions, even when circumstances are hard or a goal is out of reach.

In ACT, knowing your values gives meaning and motivation for doing hard things, including making room for uncomfortable feelings. Values are freely chosen, not "shoulds" imposed by others. Research supports ACT, which combines values work with acceptance and mindfulness, for a range of concerns.

4 WHAT CAN HELP?

Ask the values question
Alongside "What do I want to achieve?" ask "Who do I want to be in this?" or "What matters to me here?"

Link each goal to a value
For each goal, name the value it serves. If a goal stops serving that value, you're free to change the goal and keep the direction.

Take one values-based step
Choose a small action today that moves toward a value, even with doubt or discomfort along for the ride.

5 REFLECTION QUESTION

If no one would ever see or praise it, how would you still want to show up in your life?

6 KEY TAKEAWAY

Goals can be achieved; values can be lived, starting right now.

7 REFERENCES

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These resources are for education and self-reflection and are not a substitute for individualized mental health care.